MA II CRAFT !
SPRING 2025

WORDS 6210

Beneath The Surface Objects as a reflection on the wordless.

RITUAL OF TOGETHERNESS | MOUTHFUL OF KNOWLEDGE | LAYERING IMPRESSIONS OF THE SPOON

ON PHOTOGRAPHY : INDEXICAL RELATIONSHIP | JEWELLERY AND THE AESTHETIC EXPRESSION

JODIE DE VERNEY
JEWELLERY & CORPUS

Abstract

In this essay *Beneath The Surface*, I explored the themes of loss, memory, and personal identity, with a focus on the emotional impact of grief and the transformation of emotions through artistic expression. Thinking metaphorically, inspired by philosophers such as Foucault, Scruton, and Bachelard, I have examined the relationship between objects, memory, and meaning. It discusses how found objects, like spoons collected at flea markets, hold personal and historical value. These objects are deconstructed and deformed using goldsmithing techniques, symbolizing the fragmentation and reconstruction of identity.

I investigated the medium of photography, using the digitalisation process as a material reflection to speculate and wonder what exists. In doing so, I compared this medium to the casting process to mirror a complete image of physical existence. This exploration of materiality creates a tension between presence and absence which is the core aspect to this research. While this essay addresses the role of rituals, such as family dinners and votive offerings, it also explores the intimate relationship between objects and individuals. The process of material transformation, referred to as material trauma, were every manipulation of the material, such as hammering or folding, leaves a trace of tension and release. These physical actions contribute to the formation of jewellery that carries not only its own history but also reflects upon the dialogue between the maker and their surroundings. Through these techniques, fragmented pieces are reintegrated into our social structure, with the aim of enhancing their wearability and thus restoring a sense of belonging. With this project focuses on the performative act and interaction between human and object and their environment.

INDEX

Abstract 02

Introduction, My Language is visual. 04

A Bed By The Window 06

The Ritual of Togetherness 07

Mouthful of Knowledge 09

Layering Impressions of The Spoon 14

Indexical Relationship 16

Jewellery and The Aesthetic Expression 19

Conclusion 21

Appendix 22

Reference List 24

Figure List 26

Introduction, My language is visual.

I have embraced the loss of my father by transforming my emotions into expression within the language of visual arts and crafts, where thoughts and feelings that cannot be shared with reason – find their voice in the outer space. It emphasises the inner place of our minds that we as individuals characteristically use during the making process, where art becomes a part in unfolding our own motives; what's beneath the surface. Losing a parent forces you to look inward, shaped by the awareness that you never fully understood who they were. My search for the self is connected to the silence we carry within us. This reflective state gives space for the imagination to feel connected to our subjective experiences. The memories that connect us to who we are cannot always be defined but at least the emotional longing can be felt within our consciousness.

As a craftswoman, I reflect and create art based on emotions, triggers and desire. The relationship between object and maker is essential to explore the boundaries between the unattainable and the materialistic. I create a dialogue, instinctively working on a tension between conscious and uncontrolled methods of craftsmanship. When your consciousness collaborates with the hand, a sense of harmony emerges, making the noise around you disappear. By creating fleeting moments of silence that carries a narrative perspective.

In my art practice, I've been arguing with a fundamental question; Should we articulate our thoughts verbally when the meaning of our understanding is already expressed in our awareness? This thought became more prominent after reading Petra Carlsson Redell's essay 'Foucault, Art and Radical Theology: The Mystery of Things' (Redell 2009). Redell's essay engages with Paul-Michel Foucault's writings on art, examining the material and political dimensions of contemporary theology, where language challenges the ways in which concepts of identity function. Additionally, Redell introduces Jeremy Carrette's 1999 essay 'Foucault and Religion', which underscores the significance of understanding objects or things as they are. Instead of looking deeper into what we already know, we tend to focus on understanding the patterns in which these objects and things manifest within our own knowledge (Redell 2019).

Foucault's 1969 work 'L'Archéologie Du Savoir' (translated: 'The Archaeology of Knowledge'), articulates the desire to strip away the layers that obscure our perception of things. Foucault isn't trying to reveal hidden truths, but to understand how knowledge is shaped by history and society. He looks at how different systems of knowledge are formed and how power influences what we know. Instead of uncovering the truth, Foucault explores how knowledge is built and how it changes over time. Jeremy Carrette clarifies in Foucault and Religion that Foucault's approach is not about returning to a pure or original understanding of meaning, but about acknowledging and appreciating the complexity of what is. This suggests that language may not always capture the full richness and depth of reality. Foucault argues that instead of attempting to uncover hidden truths, we should examine how knowledge and power shape our understanding of the world. Complexity lives in the awareness of the forces that shape knowledge, not in the quest to reveal what lies hidden *beneath the surface* (Redell 2019).

> "ABANDONING THE NOTION OF LANGUAGE AS THAT WHICH ARTICULATES THE MUTED TRUTH - WHAT REALLY WANTS TO BE SAID - NOT ONLY AFFECTS THE VIEW OF LANGUAGE AS SUCH. IT CALLS INTO QUESTION THE DIVISION BETWEEN SIGNIFIER AND SIGNIFIED, ABSTRACTION AND REALITY. BY EXTENSION IT DISRUPTS THE NOTION THAT WORDS AND THINGS HAVE DISTINCT, SEPARATE FUNCTIONS IN OUR KNOWLEDGE." (Redell 2019, p. 9).

As in art and craft, there is an attempt to express the wordless, intertwining Foucault's ideas with personal experiences. This suggests that language cannot fully capture the depth of personal identity. For my master's project, *Beneath the Surface*, I'm exploring the layers of my past, aiming to uncover them through the creative process, yet without fully exposing them. It is a journey of discovery within the cultural context, where our collective longing for the self becomes visible.

The research starts by finding and collecting objects on flea markets. Where fragments of the past and personal memories can be found. Using goldsmithing techniques, I deconstruct and reframe these objects to explore the absence. By letting the material speak and isolating its functional presence, a new story unfolds in the viewer's mind, creating an intimate space of introverted silence. This approach focuses on representing the personal and the subjective, exploring the space between the familiar and the mysterious. In doing so, it questions how we can meet the challenge of connecting personal memories with public expression, while navigating through the tension between individual experiences and shared interpretations.

Laat eerst de wind stil gaan liggen.	First, let the wind go silent.
Laat de bladeren zwijgen	Let the leaves fall silent
en de insecten,	and the insects,
het oppervlak dat huivert	the surface that shivers
van het bloed	from the blood
laat dat glad worden.	let that smooth over.
Laat overheersen	Let prevail
Het instinct van stilte.	The instinct of silence.
Gesel, oneindigheid en roekeloosheid	Scourge, infinity, and recklessness
Laat ze opgaan in herinnering	Let them dissolve into memory.
Laat later ook de herinnering vervagen.	Let even the memory fade later.
Uiteindelijk	In the end,
Kan het gaan regenen.	it might start to rain.

(poezieiseendaad 2022)

A Bed by The Window

On the first of September, I received the sad news. I was ten years old when my father died. He died of cancer, an incurable disease that overshadowed my family in the year 2007. As a little girl, these moments in my life were very difficult to understand. At that age, children have a good understanding of what death is, which makes them ask fewer questions and may not always express their emotions directly. Home felt strange, people around me whom I barely recognised sang in sorrow. Across the room, I saw my mum. She was looking at me, but her gaze was blank. Her presence felt barely noticeable. At the dining table, I had separated myself from the situation. There I sat. Staring at a blank sheet of paper. The crayons in my hand slowly lost their vividness. As I sighed and approached the paper with the pencil tip, whatever I had in mind faded away, like a shadow that lingered on for a while.

Grieving after the loss of my father was an unpredictable process, and it still is. The silence that has been left in the unknown continues to exist. It is a constant absence that gets in my way, something I have had to learn to live with. The children's book 'Een Bed Bij Het Raam' (Vanden Heede 2007) (translated: 'A Bed By The Window') helped me better understand my own situation after his passing away. In this story, the author Sylvia Vanden Heede tells the narrative of Stan, who needed to accept that his mother will not get better (De Kinder 2007). This made me realise that the man who always took care and protected me was no longer with me (Vanden Heede 2007).

Nowadays, looking back on my childhood with the Dutch song 'Voor ik vergeet' (Spinvis 2002) (translated: 'Before I forget') by Spinvis in which musician Erik de Jong expressed the fear of forgetting. The small but meaningful things, that makes a difference in life like: "Alle woorden en elk uur de hele dag – en ook de nacht en de zomers" (translated: "All the words and every hour the whole day - and also the night and summers") (Spinvis 2002, 1:59) is holding on to a powerful image yet those moments are forgettable. The attempt to remember is more reachable than the memory itself. The image, so fundamental to who we are, is often distorted by time and loss. When I look at my hands, I see not only my father's reflection but also the constant presence of something that is missing. It is this emptiness, the silence that makes it so difficult to fully embrace what was once so clear because "De handen van mijn vader ... die vergeet ik op den duur" (translated: "My father's hands ... will forget over time") (Spinvis 2002, 2:07).



Fig.01: Een bed bij het raam. (Jan De Kinder 2007) Lannoo.

The Ritual of Togetherness

On a hot summer day, nerves flourished inside of me as I walked into the house where my partner had spent his entire childhood, about to meet his family for the first time. His mother welcomed me warmly and invited me to join them for dinner that evening. As we sat at the table, I noticed the atmosphere was more relaxed than I was used to at my home. The seven o'clock news played in the background while we ate in silence. Occasionally, a word was exchanged, but my presence seemed almost unnoticed. Despite a hint of tension, I felt at ease, comforted by their unchanging ritual at the table. By the end of the evening, I realized that I no longer felt like an outsider. I had become a part of his world, a world that now felt a little more familiar to me.

The dining table is a place where interactions take place, this space in the home plays a crucial role where we nurture our sense of belonging. Coming together invites people to share a moment and this at a specific hour of the day. Out of these rituals traditions are formed, the weekly family dinner is an experience that is lived differently for each family. The ritual begins with gathering and setting the table. Since my father's death, this ritual has not returned to me. Settling a table is no longer a tradition but a reminder of every second you were grieving, felt the fear of abandoned and being lost by that presence. It is these moments in life that make you pause and reflect on the absence.

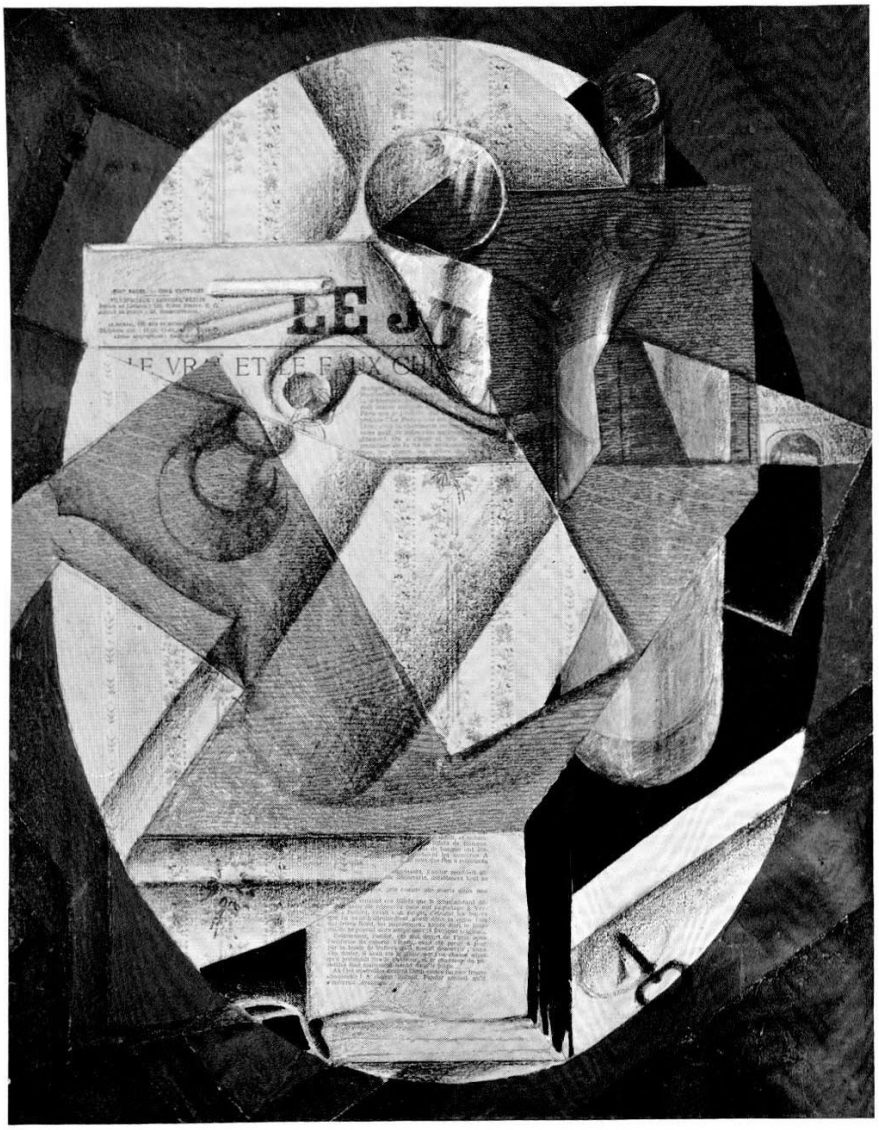
> "SILENCE IS NOT THE ABSENCE OF SOMETHING, BUT THE PRESENCE OF EVERYTHING." (Science and Nonduality, n.d.).

In 2013 journalist Wim Kayzer engages with philosopher Roger Scruton in a reflective dialogue during a hunting expedition, prompting him to contemplate the fundamental aspects of human existence. Kayzer poses a series of existential questions, asking: "Tell me what makes this life worth living. In what do we find beauty and is there anything to be said about that beauty? Why do we seem to know so much more about our frustrations? And what are we actually comforted by? What, in other words, are the memories or expectations that are greater than our grief" (VPRO Metropolis 2013).

When we seek comfort, we are essentially searching for a sense of belonging in the world. British philosopher Roger Scruton refers to this as an abstract form of comfort, in which we seek reconciliation from our fragmented existence, bringing us back together. This longing is evident in religion, as the notion that life on Earth is incomplete and that there must be more resonates with many, even those who do not consider themselves religious. Scruton portrays the concept of God as a community beyond the living, the dead, and the unborn. The roots of religion run deep within us, as we all have a fundamental need for connection to something greater, to stand still, and to experience life alongside others (VPRO Metropolis 2013, 1:23:23).

Roger Scruton explains their idea of returning to a natural state that civilized humans have lost over time, as a search for beauty in a way that regains lost connections. Hunting is seen as a metaphor for the return to the pure, a state in which we exist not as isolated individuals but as part of a greater whole. It is argued that we feel unhappy and estranged when we place too much emphasis on the individual, whereas we find solace and meaning by merging into something larger than ourselves, such as a shared history and continuity. "But what do we long for as human beings?" (VPRO Metropolis 2013, 1:23:45).

The focus of my master project is an exploration of the concept of rituals that encourage interactions between objects and people, and the manner in which a piece of jewellery can acquire meaning within the setting of an exhibition space. This thesis includes a chapter entitled 'Jewellery and Aesthetic Expression', which addresses the research question: In what ways can jewellery transcend social expectations? In what ways can jewellery transcend social expectations?



The Table. 1914. Collage and gouache on canvas, 23½ × 17⅛". Philadelphia Museum of Art, A. E. Gallatin Collection 58.143 ✓ (sight: 23¼ × 17½")

45

Fig.02: The Table. (Juan Gris 1914).

Mouthful of Knowledge

Traces of buried and abandoned places are an inspiration for my work. I use the flea market as a site to collect and explore new knowledge. It serves as a gathering place where the past is left behind. By sharing as a community, we allow our stories to live on. In this way, we unfold a way between memory and history. The search for antiques is based on intuition and wonder about possible encounters in life, those moments that feel predestined but have not yet crossed my path, making me curious about what lies beyond.

During my master's studies, I collected spoons and their belonging boxes at flea markets in Europe (De Verney 2023). These objects have grown into treasures and developed an antique quality over time. As I thought critically about the prevalence of mass production in contemporary society, I have come to understand that my generation's acquaintance with silver spoons is mostly restricted to occasional, celebratory visits to our grandparents' homes. This highlights the special value we placed on such objects. There are differences between families in the objects or meanings they share, which becomes noticeable when we compare Western and Eastern cultures. In the early years of our lives, the information that forms our self-awareness is determined primarily by physical interactions with the symbols in our domestic environment. The idea of collecting spoons developed from this understanding, the one thing that connects us to the familiar.



Fig.03: Flea Market. (Jodie De Verney 2023).

The spoons serve as a metaphor for the individual; the boxes are the bearers that refer to home, a place to which we all belong. The spoon is a traditional object that evokes domesticity, an instrument that makes our basic needs function that is connected to our body: the mouth, the act of intimacy and the hands, containing the act of caregiving by nourishing others and ourself. As a collector of spoons, I make a connection between them and the care of jewellery. Often these wearable pieces are housed in boxes covered with a velvet or ‘faux’ silk fabric to protect and present them aesthetically. Its emphases the preserving aspect that holds their value over time rather than the will to use it.

In the podcast ‘Material Matters’, Grant Gibson and metalsmith Simone ten Hompel discussed what a spoon stands for other than its functional purpose. Questioning the way, we use something and interact with it. ten Hompel argues “We start our life using a spoon, it’s the first tool that we hold in our hands, so it becomes a metaphor for life itself” (Material Matters 2018, 25:52).

When collecting, I not only gather the physical objects but also invite to share the stories that are associated with them. I encourage people in my surroundings to explore my findings either in person or via digital platforms like social media. I use the medium of photography where I can share photos with a wider audience. In addition, I ask questions on the site itself what they mean to the seller and what historical or cultural context they might have. This deepened my perception that objects serve as vessels for memories. During research I discovered the tradition of offering a silver spoon to newborns as a birth gift in Europe. This tradition is perceived as a gesture of goodwill and a sign of future prosperity. However, it feels outdated to me, as it no longer holds the same relevance as today. Although the silver spoon as a physical gift may feel out of place in these modern times, its symbolic meaning remains strong, especially in use of language. The phrase ‘born with a silver spoon in its mouth’ still carries the same weight in contemporary society. Which refers to someone who is born into a wealthy family and therefore is in a privileged position. Such phrases reflect how language is linked to cultural norms. Although these traditions are slowly disappearing, these language expressions demonstrate that the concept of wealth continues to shape societal perceptions and remains tied to material value.

“SINCE THE BIRTH OF HUMANS AS SENTIENT BEINGS, WE HAVE BELIEVED IN THE ANIMISTIC NATURE OF THINGS – OF PLANTS, ANIMALS AND MAN-MADE OBJECTS – VIEWING THEM AS LIVING ENTITIES WITH A SPIRITUAL ESSENCE. THIS IDEA HAS ATTRACTED BOTH MODERNIST AND CONTEMPORARY ARTISTS” (Fite-Wassilak 2018).

The surrealist André Breton visited the Saint-Ouen flea market in Paris in the year 1934, where he found a wooden spoon carved in the shape of a shoe (Ray 1934). Breton didn’t know what he had found, only that he recognised this artefact from his dreams (Fite-Wassilak 2018). This object inspired an important idea for the creation of dream objects. These are small collections of things that are brought together by text. The metaphor of the human body illustrates this: the poem is the body, the objects are the organs, and the letters of the words are the cells components (Dean 2024). The ‘Poème-Objets’ (Breton 1935) made in 1935 is an assemblage of cardboard, wood, photo and a plaster egg, with the words ‘Je Vois / J’Imagine’ (translated: ‘I see / I imagine’) applied in a handwritten text. All these elements work together as a reflection of Brenton’s inner mind. These objects are an analytical tool that could be observed like a dream (National Gallery of Scotland 2020).

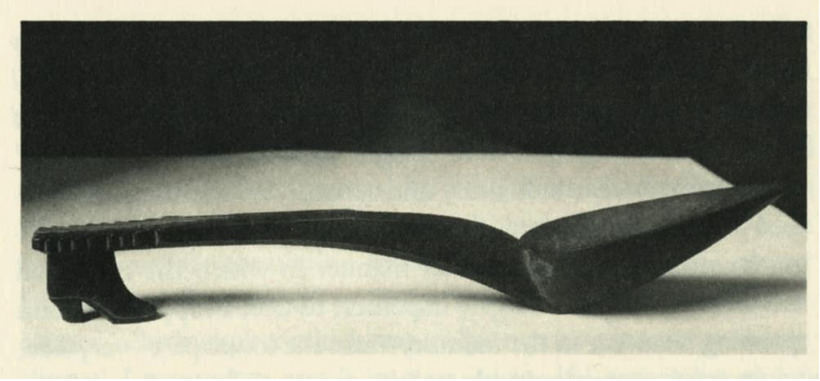


Fig.04: André Brenton’s ‘Slipper Spoon’. (Man Ray 1934).



Fig.05: Poème Objet. (André Breton 1935).

André Breton emphasized the power of everyday found objects, arguing that they could reveal hidden desires of the subconscious. The Surrealists saw objects as possessing an inner essence in which everything had a spirit. In Europe from the early 20th century onwards, thinking about how objects could be re-contextualised gave deeper meaning, a concept that is still being explored. In 1929, English philosopher Alfred North Whitehead described an object as something that in itself has no meaning 'an empty actuality', to be defined from the context in which it is located and their relations to other things. Much contemporary art follows this idea, especially art that critiques how we view art, or art that explores how difficult it is to be objective. This questions us not just to look at objects, but trying to understand how they function outside their usual context, for example by disconnecting them from their time or place. The idea follows that art can help us see the true essence of things, beyond ordinary interpretations, and give space for objects to speak for themselves. The Surrealistic dream object allows us to look back in history, a sensation Breton captures when he first encounters the spoon—an experience I recognise myself. Whether it's at a flea market, in a museum, or at our grandparents' home, we're surrounded by objects that connect us to the physical world (Fite-Wassilak 2018).

Every Sunday, near the historic centre of Antwerp there is a flea market where you can discover old treasures and hidden curiosities. Each stand displays a kind of domesticity, staged as a performance where each object presents itself among others. Trying to stand out. Over the centuries, numerous commercial activities have taken place on the Sint-Jans Vliet square. This place used to be a harbour, but in the late 9th century it turned into a thriving market where merchants sold their valuable goods, laying the foundation for the antiques market it is today. It's an ever-changing place where the old and the new await us.

From a distance, there is one stand that caught my eye. I walked a little bit closer; the delicate candleholders, jewellery, and cutlery seem to carry echoes where each piece waits to be grasped. I find myself drawn to a particular item and, as I carefully hold it, I feel the object come alive in my hands, activating its hidden narrative.

From the mid-16th century, spoons were made out of tin and silver. The discovery of America and the increase in precious metals led to more opportunities for gold and silversmiths across Europe. The Italian Renaissance was spreading to Western Europe which influenced the craft of silversmithing. The first spoon had a round bowl and a short, round handle with decorated knobs. It was only towards the end of the 18th century that the spoon took on the shape we know today, with an oval bowl that later became longer and narrower, with the pointed oval shape being in common use by the end of the century. The handle was forged from a single piece of metal, eliminating the joint behind the spoon body, but sometimes it remained suggestively through a decorative element (Hughes 1990).

In the Middle Ages, the spoon was more than an utensil; it was a sign of distinction, a symbol of one's wealth and status. Owning a ‘silver’ spoon was a silent declaration of privilege. But when I look for a spoon today, I am less charmed by this historical claim or the polished metal itself. While silver has an aesthetic appeal in its fine brilliance, my preference lies in the delicacy for silver-plated non precious metals. The craftsmanship in this layer has a subtle impact: after exposure to air, a thin oxidation gradually appears on the surface. With use, the metal underneath may become visible. Although silver-plated objects do not have the enduring qualities, they do give an evidence of time (De Verney 2023)

“THE SUGGESTION OF NATURAL PROCESS RECORD THE SUN, WIND, RAIN, HEAT AND COLD IN A LANGUAGE OF DISCOLORATION RUST, TARNISH, STAIN, WARPING, SHRINKING, SHRIVELING AND CRACKING. THEIR NICKS, CHIPS, BRUISES, SCARS, DENTS, PEELING, AND OTHER FORMS OF ATTRITION ARE A TESTAMENT TO HISTORIES OF USE AND MISUSE ”
(Koren 2008, p.62).

The essay ‘In Praise of the shadows’ (Tanizaki 2011) on the aesthetics of Japanese philosophies raises the cultural differences between Asia and the Western world, and how differently we treat our everyday objects. In the Western tradition the silverware is polished to a fine brilliance meanwhile in Japanese culture they respect the imperfections of impurity and age. Following their beliefs that the philosophy of the darkness builds layers over a period that create a heightened sense of touch that manifests life and leaves their marks on the outside (Tanizaki 2011, p.18).



Fig.06: Fragments Spoons 1. (Jodie De Verney 2023).

The desire for a consistent appearance of knife, spoon and fork became increasingly visible from the 18th century onwards, with, for example, identical handles for knife and fork to achieve consistency in tableware. The tradition of keeping spoons in boxes occurs from this period when cutlery sets were often seen as luxury items. In the 19th century, cutlery sets became of higher quality with the use of stainless steel. Cutlery was often kept in special wooden or leather cases to protect and present it as a valuable treasure. These cutlery sets were often passed down as inheritance pieces (Hughes 1990).

The way the spoons nestle into the boxes suggests the act of spooning, both literally and figuratively. It evokes the idea of tenderness and connection, even if that connection is not physically present. The phrase ‘spooning’ is often used to describe how two people lie side by side, with one behind the other, like spoons fitting exactly together.

In the 2014 edition of ‘The Poetics of Space’ (Bachelard 2014) on architecture, analyse French philosopher Gaston Bachelard the method of phenomenology, in which he refers to lived experiences within the architectural context. Bachelard studies the emotional response through spatial types such as the drawers, chest and wardrobes (Bachelard 2014, p.95).

On the contrary, I investigate the phenomenon of a box that can be placed in the same contextual image; We can experience a box in different ways, depending on whether it is closed or opened. When closed, it carries an aura of mystery, containing the external world’s noise. However, once opened, the experience begins to unfold, and in that moment, we cross into a space of intimacy.

“WE OPEN IT AND DISCOVER THAT IS A DWELLING PLACE, THAT A HOUSE IS HIDDEN IN IT” (Bachelard 2014, p.107).

The philosopher argues that without such objects, the intimacy of our lives would be fundamentally altered. These items are both functional and deeply personal, carrying with them a sense of intimacy. Specifically, the wardrobe, as Bachelard illustrates, represents a space of order that protects the household from disorder. This strategy is not merely geometric but also remembers the family history (Bachelard 2014, p.100).

When I visit the market, I am not only looking for new finds, but this place also offers a kind of comfort. Many of the items are stacked in cardboard boxes, and for me the practicality of this has a deeper, emotional meaning. The logo on the boxes (De Verney 2025) reminds me of a manufacturer my father used to work for. It feels like it brings me closer to his presence. With no physical memories of him left, my longing for that place seems to become more important.



Fig.07: Archive Dad. (Jodie De Verney 2025).

Layering Impressions of The Spoon

The collected spoons are deconstructed and deformed using goldsmithing techniques, deviated from their purpose of use. It is a search for my understanding of what is lost or missing, to find a connection to a hidden knowledge. The idea of reusing and recontextualizing materials is to enhance their wearability that restores a sense of belonging. I move towards a dialogue in which fragmented objects are reintegrated into our social structure through the use of jewellery.

The material undergoes various transformations. The layers revealing the narration of tension and release, where time and touch merge together. It contains the memory of the past as well as the potential for future change while preserving the traces created by previous interactions of environment and the physical touch.

The act of fragmenting the metal spoons through sawing invites a critical reflection on the traditional conception of functionality. When exploring the practical use of things that is kinetically dependent it needs someone or something to activate it. The completeness of a functioning instrument has much more energy in action than an object in motion. It has a practical purpose, while the functioning instrument reaches its full potential when put into action (Risatti 2009, p.25). So I can conclude from this that transforming a spoon changes its potential allowing it to exist independently.



Fig.08: Fragments Spoons 2. (Jodie De Verney 2023).

This crafting method breathes life into a generation of forms (De Verney 2023), each detached from the archetypal representation of the “spoon”, where the physical reality of the missing piece may not exist, yet can be manifested through imagination. The non-existent or separated part becomes an impression or void, suggesting a form that is hidden or completed in the viewers mind. The transformation process prevents the objects from behaving as in their original condition. Here I am reflecting on how we humans evolve over time. Because of our adaptability, the environment around us will not always evolve at the same time. When the spoons return to their box, they evolve into a completely different entity.

The introspective search is intertwined with how our personality forms and distorts due to the circumstances we experience as human beings. In psychology, the term trauma is used when someone's feelings stagnate after an event. The natural processing of emotions and experiences can be disrupted as a result of emotional blockages. It emphasizes how trauma can become "stuck" in the body and mind, preventing from healing oneself (van der Kolk 2014).

British novelist and poet Deborah Levy, known for her work on gender politics and philosophy, also explains the term in one of the chapters of her book ‘The Position of the Spoon and Other Intimacies’ (Levy 2024). She shares her personal thoughts and experiences that have shaped her as an individual. Levy formulate trauma as an experience that unintentionally expands one's knowledge, and in this way, recounting the details of a traumatic event offers a sense of control over an unwanted knowledge. She compares this as example to an investigation of an airplane crash, where the cockpit voice recorder or “black box” is searched to reveal the events leading up to the accident. She suggests that by recounting our memories of an accident - whether we were witnesses or experienced it ourselves - we become the black box (Levy 2024, p.69). In reflecting on this, I believe that memories are like hidden layers. Even though early memories can be hard to access, they still seem to shape how we feel and react in the present.



Fig.09: Workbench. (Jodie De Verney 2023).

The physicality of the craft processes of hammering and folding metal documents a material-based trauma. This suggests that the process of forming and deforming leaves a trace. These applied techniques (De Verney) mark a presence of transformation that takes place during the making. Describing it as a 'material-based trauma' evokes the idea that the metal is 'experiencing' something in a moment of stress and tension. In which I, as the maker, push myself to the limits of what is possible. In this way I create a dialogue with the object. An interaction where I challenge its endurance. How far can I stretch the metal? When do I reach the edge that defines my limits? At what point does it whisper to rest, before it splits, before the moment disappears? Roll milling is a metal forming process where the metal is passed through rollers to reduce its thickness without preheating the metal, is known as cold rolling. During this process, the mechanical stress changes the crystal structure of the metal, which increases its strength. In this way I preserve the oxidation patterns and signs of use. The spoons carry the scars of their functional identity, similar to how trauma can leave permanent marks on people. This working method gives me the opportunity to understand the process of making more deeply. Each new action fades the original impression, but the influence of previous craftsmanship remains until a faded surface appear that refers to an erased image.

When I was guiding a spoon through the roller manually. I felt something obstructing its path, causing me to roll it back. It struck me how I rely on my sense of touch to detect these issues. I discovered that the piece was made of several parts and noticed a solder joint that was loose, changing the shape and exposing the use of different layers of metal. This moment felt precious because in a way it brought me closer to the person who had originally made it. It was as if I had discovered not only the physical limits of the object, but also a piece of history hidden in the hands of the person who made it. The delicately imprinted fragments reveal this presence on the surface, forming a choreography of use that marks their existence over time. It is in these connections that new discovery is embodied.

Indexical Relationship

Losing my father inspired me to dive deeper into his passion for photography, as he was a professional in the field. In many ways, exploring this medium brought me closer to who he was. Through this journey, I gained a deeper appreciation for the essence of photography—recognizing the importance of details, composition, and form. By analysing the world through a lens, I have learnt to strengthen my view with more precision. I started to appreciate the unnoticed details in our surroundings with all its imperfections: things impermanent and incomplete. Yet the experience I gained as a craftswoman has shown that the body is often forgotten during the making because it requires little or no tools to create the work. This becomes almost second nature, allowing me to focus more on the creation itself than the technique behind it. As a photographer, the situation is different: I'm constantly aware of the camera in my hands.

The English artist and one of the most prominent representatives of pop art, David Hockney, criticizes photography for the limitations it imposes on our perception of reality: "I figured out what's wrong with the photography. It's basically about a one-eyed man looking through a hole. How can that be a representation of reality?" (Caroll 2018, p.14).

With this, I share Hockney's thoughts on the use of cameras, with their lens and framing, they present an unnatural perspective in which our peripheral vision disappears. This flattens the space due to the fact that only one snapshot is shown from one angle. In the 1980s, Hockney explored these limitations through photo collages. In the 2015 work 'The Meeting in the Studio' (Hockney 1937), he combined photographs with digital technology to create photographic drawings, disrupting space and time. This results in a distorted image in which perspectives and temporal dimensions are no longer aligned, something Hockney sees as an approach to an actual human perception (Carroll 2018, p.14).



Fig.10: The Studio Meeting. (David Hockney 1937).

From the question of what makes an image an image, led me to a conclusion that both photography and other crafts reflect the real world and share the same qualities that are not fully considered the truth. This led me to the idea, which can be interpreted similarly to Hockney's concept, of merging different perspectives into a complete picture of reality. Experimentation is the necessary method here. Moreover, the material has a certain 'will' that makes the artist no longer responsible for the result.

In 'One and Three Chairs' (Kosuth 1965), the American artist and photographer Joseph Kosuth presents three different representations of a chair: an unfolded wooden chair, a photograph of this chair and a dictionary definition of the word chair.

By bringing these three forms of reality together, Kosuth confronts the nature of representation and meaning. The work contains a visual philosophy of language. Something I want to strive for myself. This raises the question of which representation of the chair is the most accurate. Kosuth's aim is not to provide answers, but to encourage the viewer to think about art as a process of meaning-making, where the chair turns into an object of debate and reflection (Kosuth 1999).



Fig.11: One and Three Chairs. (Joseph Kosuth 1965).

The physical structure of an object in its true environment determines an atmosphere of authenticity. Removing the context creates a visual poem that raises more questions than it answers. When one makes a reproduction, the situation changes. Over time, new sensory perceptions develop. I use plaster to make casts from the spoon boxes, allowing me to create variations. These will be assembled with other 'captured' materials such as, porcelain, wood, paper, fabric to reflect the full reality of the box. The idea of immortality through the process of mould making offers a possibility to experience the presence of absence.

A Journal written by Joan Gibbons 'Contemporary Art, and Memory' (Gibbons 2007) explained the indexical relationship between the casting process and photography. The most used medium to capture a subject is the use of a camera. Gibbons uses Rachel Whiteread as an example that can be compared with my idea follows of preserving. Whiteread made sculptures that are a direct cast of an object. In 1990 she made the work Ghost (Whiteread 1990) which is a room-sized sculpture that defines the space between the positives and the negatives. In the digital field we only see a cropped version of our larger scaled reality. In a casting, a lot of information got lost by recreating a form. There is a gap, a moment between the object and the cast that puts tension in time. The index of this abstraction is fragile in their appearance, the use of these techniques mimics things and by capturing it, the physicality disconnects from the previous and becomes its own belongings (Gibbons 2007, p. 29).



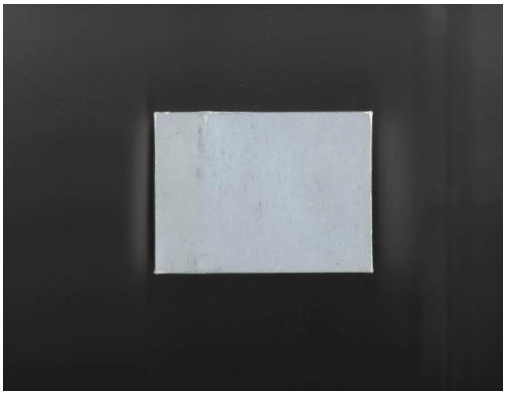
Fig.12: Ghost. (Rachel Whiteread 1990).

While looking through analogue photographs from my childhood, I came across a printed image (De Verney 1997) - a scan of my hands taken around the time I was born in 1997. I clearly recognised my own imprint; the hand lines are still the same. This was the only information I could read and recognize; this is me. It gave me to the idea to create a photo archive by scanning the spoon boxes (De Verney 2023), offering a unique glimpse into the mystery of the unknown. This process captures not only the physical details of each box, but also the cultural stories they embody.

This methodical exploration using technology illustrates how information can be expanded, highlighting the ongoing journey from mystery to perception. By using the supplement printer, I transferred scanned images onto fabric, capturing the essence within the fibres of the fabric. This process led me to the unexpected reference of The Veil of Veronica (de Zurbarán 1658). According to this enigma, the cloth with the image of the Holy Face of Christ would have been used by Jesus himself to wipe the blood and sweat from their face. Miraculously, the image appeared on the cloth which has been honoured as a holy relic since. Such portraits contributed to the rise of faith in self-fulfilling miracles (Delenda 2013, p.3). This prompted to consider what figurative meaning the image (De Verney 2024) in my work might convey.

Fig.13: Scan Box. (Jodie De Verney 2023).

Fig.14: Scan Hands. (Jodie De Verney 1997).



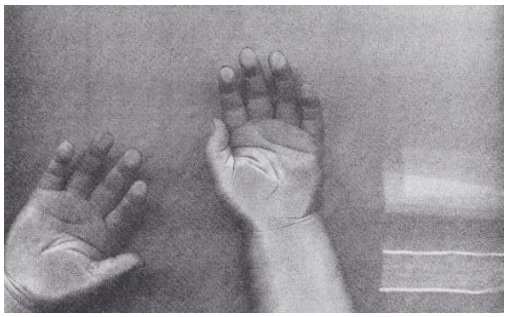






Fig.15: Print on Fabric. (Jodie De Verney 2024).

Fig.16: The Holy Face. (Francisco de Zurbarán 1658).

Jewellery And The Aesthetic Expression

Wearing jewellery is a practice often associated with the ritual of bringing new life. Rituals themselves are often imbued with symbolism and actions that evoke emotions, memories and even spiritual experiences. We understand jewellery partly through the stories they carry. It is the most intimate art form, often in direct contact with the skin that visualise our identity.

The impact of jewellery on the body, highlights the transformative nature of objects. In the book 'On Jewellery: A Compendium of International contemporary art jewellery', the theory of this transformation is discussed as 'reading jewellery' (Besten 2013). The Dutch author and art historian Liesebeth den Besten describes jewellery in relation to the maker, the viewer and the wearer. She wrote that jewellery is not simply presented as an ornament for the wearer or as a symbol of wealth. As objects, they seek to convey meaning or content, similar to visual arts. The distinction lies in the fact that jewellery is worn on the body. In the late 1970s, the wearer was expected to interact with the jewellery, for instance by changing it or playing with it. This refers to the objectification of jewellery, a term that describes the phenomenon whereby jewellery is seen not only as decoration, but also as symbols of independence and autonomy. This led to a new relationship between the jewellery and the wearer, where the person had to relate to the object. With the influence of changing trends within the visual arts, jewellery was increasingly seen as an art object, a medium in which stories could be told. Meaning and content of jewellery are not only determined by the maker, but are also significantly influenced and constructed by the wearer (Besten 2013, pp. 60-106).

The deconstructed spoons contain the ritual idea that stimulates interaction between objects and individuals. In this concept, I focus on an exhibition space in which the spoon acts as a portal towards a ritual experience, involving the viewer. This will be done through an arrangement that invites for an active participation. The object itself can trigger the movement. As the maker, I can't control what happens in that moment. The focus is on the 'experience', with the person wearing it being responsible. Holding it In their hands. Seeking a performance to reach the surface.

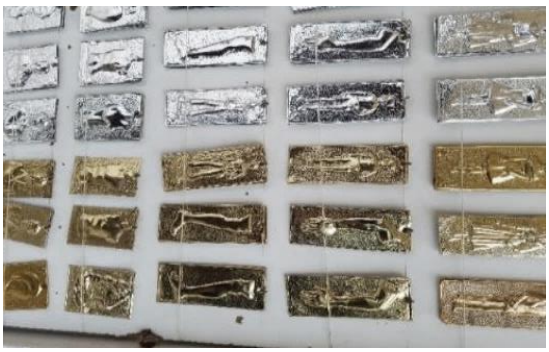


Fig.17: Tamata ata for Sale along the Leoforos Megalochares, Tinos. (Unknown 2020).

Creating a ritual became a process that drew inspiration from historical practices. For this research, Professor of European and Classical Languages Steven M. Oberhelman's wrote an article that gave insight for the role of votives as a narrative tool. Within the context of healing, faith and socio-cultural discourse in classical and Byzantine Greece, votives were traditionally offered in sacred spaces. These were objects that were believed to have healing powers. People visited shrines to seek protection or to honour loved ones. The practice of sacrifice as an expression of gratitude is exemplified by the widespread belief in the divine. These offerings, often mass-produced and made of materials such as tin, silver or gold, took the form of miniature figures on metal plates representing body parts (Unknown 2020). In a similar manner, the proportion of the spoon could be applied as a figurative symbol, which also possesses its own anatomy (Oberhelman 2019, p.22).

The traditions passed down in my family are rituals that are also familiar to others. At every important occasion, we light up a candle, no matter where we are. The flame is a silent gesture, a moment to take a breath, whisper encouragement to ourself or offer gratitude to those who are no longer with us. Lighting a candle in church is a well-known fact. It is a way to pray. Many people light candles to honour the dead. It can be a personal act, but it happens within the context of a community. This reflects the continuing cultural significance of votives as personal devotions and as part of a larger socio-cultural ritual.

The church offers an intimate atmosphere, despite the space being quite open. I examined this architectural setting through the lens of Bachelard's philosophy to search for the same quality in an exhibition space, in which the relation between human and their environment is expressed. The chapter ‘Corners’ from the book ‘The Poetics of Space’ (Bachelard 2014) provided an answer to my question about the most intimate place within a space: “Every corner in a house, every angle in a room, every inch of secluded space in which we like to hide, or withdraw into ourselves, is a symbol of solitude for the imagination; that is to say, it is the germ of a room or a house” (Bachelard 2014, p.156).



Fig.18: Installation View. (Jodie De Verney 2023).

Conclusion

During the field studies, I visited locations where flea markets were organised. These places made me reflect on the amount of things we accumulate throughout our lives. Over time, these objects decay within our cultural context. The artefacts, such as spoon boxes, gradually become redundant because their original functions no longer exist in the contemporary world.

Consumer culture reduces information and memories, which are constantly valued in our daily lives. The spread of mass production has led to the standardisation of things. There is less emphasis on craftsmanship. People can no longer feel connected to the origin of objects because the industry is so far removed from the user experience. Through collecting and the recreation process, I hope to raise awareness about this issue, in order to try to embody the essence of objects within our culture. To extend the knowledge further, I want to gather the traditions of the ornamental features of the spoons, as well as the maker's stamp, which provides valuable insights into our culture heritage.

The knowledge they share with us is often limited to museums, this influences our perception of how we interact with objects. Therefore, I find it interesting to integrate the structural information I gathered at the flea market into the ‘white space’. In this way, a combinations of different worlds is created, bringing the ultimate image to life and making it tangible. To further development of this project, I would like to write a report for the next stages, as a written document in which I record my experience. Such as weather condition, atmosphere and the people around me. In my thesis, I also discuss the creation of a photo archive that I aim to build in the coming years, and what would complete the project is the addition of a diary.

The challenge of connecting personal memories with public expression revolves around the dynamics between individuals and shared spaces. In this context, I want to research into the architectural way of thinking about spaces, with particular attention to the interaction and relation between the home and an object. How does the space breath in relation to the objects within? Additionally, I am interested in the relationship between human movement and the habits we develop in our daily lives. For example, how we always brush our hair, with a the same hand and in a familiar, quiet posture. Within this spatial context, this insight could contribute to the experience of art installations and performative objects.

The ritual object, the spoon, serves as a metaphor for the individual and forms an essential part of my project, in which I further investigate the role of jewellery in this context. The question is how these objects can be set in motion. This exploration of the interaction between object and human will be analysed further after the masters exhibition in April 2025, as the objects only come to life ‘active’ when they are set up and accessible to the public. The goal of the exam project is to present these objects in different locations, so that I can analyse how different cultures approach these rituals and how the transition to the aesthetic aspect of mourning develops.

Appendix

Between Inside and Outside: Transitional Spaces and Intimate Gestures

Weeks before the graduation exhibition, I began a series of tests in the studio, with the framework already clearly defined: the work had to resonate with the places where the found objects originally came from. Not as a literal reconstruction, but as an atmospheric translation of the outside world into a concentrated interior space. This shift raised fundamental questions: how do you bring the sensation of an urban environment into an exhibition space? How do you preserve the specific quality of a place when it is removed from its original context?

In conversations with colleagues , it was suggested that the work be shown in a smaller, more sheltered space, an idea that matched the scale and sensitivity of my work. Nevertheless, I chose to position the work in the open, public space of Vita Havet. Not out of disagreement, but out of curiosity: how does a work that seeks stillness behave within a visual polyphony? My work does not claim attention. Rather, it aims to function as a resting point, a place for slowed perception. Much like in a church or a moment of contemplation in public space, there needs to be a moment to breathe, to feel, and to listen. The open space turned out not to contradict this intention, but instead offered a counterpoint: a place where stillness could unexpectedly emerge.

Reflection after the Examination

The examination proved, as hoped, to be a meaningful enrichment within the developmental process of my practice. The conversation with the opponents brought not only valuable insights, but also a fundamental question : do the objects speak louder than my own voice? This question partly arose from suggestions concerning potential shifts in my research methodology—such as the ‘finding’ of objects through platforms like eBay. This was proposed as an alternative approach that shifted my focus to processes of production, a direction I intend to explore further and anchor theoretically at a later stage.

The dialogue with two other craft makers brought a confronting but valuable realisation: my work contains multiple layers, but this complexity demands a refinement in how I articulate it. Not the work itself, but the way it is communicated deserves further alignment. Interestingly, writing such as when drafting an open call, contributes to sharpening my future vision. Here, language serves as a tool for clarity, making my intentions more tangible and communicable, not only for myself but also for others.

Spring Exhibition

In the 2025 edition of the Spring Exhibition, I presented my work within a more compact, enclosed exhibition setting. The chosen placement in a corner of the space, the most secluded and intimate zone, formed the starting point. This place demanded a conscious materiality: I decided to fix the fragmentary spoons not with hooks, but directly with nails into the wall. This seemingly small shift in presentation brought the work closer to the physical structure of the space and intensified the confrontation between object and viewer.

Despite or perhaps because of the positioning in a corner, a charged moment of dialogue emerged. Each object was now given space to exist autonomously while simultaneously becoming part of a larger spatial composition. Whereas the graduation exhibition was marked by stricter time constraints, this exhibition offered room for reflection. The extra time made it possible not only to create a setup but to truly investigate how objects relate to the space and vice versa.

No pre-set scenography was applied. Instead, I worked with the experience of the previous presentation as a silent reference. An intervention such as adding a wall does not imply expansion, nor assimilation within the existing architectural logic. On the contrary: it functions as a temporary interruption that affirms the primacy of the existing walls. This awareness of scale, tactility, and presence has further refined my thinking around installation-based interventions.

What Now?

What follows is a deepening of this practice through a residency in which I will work on a research platform: a logbook that brings together personal observations, theoretical reflections, and visual documentation. These trajectories offer space to broaden my research questions: which objects are considered heritage? And how do systems of value attribution function within the social and cultural logic of the present?

In addition, I will continue to develop a performative installations as spatial compositions in which public participation and ritual are central. The relationship between object, space, and body remains a core concept. Through gestures, I want to explore new forms of touch, care, and collective memory, where ritual is not repeated, but reinvented. My artistic practice thus moves further towards an aesthetics of repair: a poetic and political gesture that creates space for connection, presence, and transformation.



Fig.19: Installation View Spring exhibition. (Jodie De Verney 2025).

Reference List

Bachelard, G. (2014). *The poetics of space*. London: Penguin Books.

Besten, den, E.L. (2013). *On jewellery: A compendium of international contemporary art jewellery*. Stuttgart: Arnoldsche Art Publishers.

Carroll, H. (2018). *Fotografen over fotografie: Hoe de meesters kijken, denken & werken*. Tielt: Luster.

Dean, R. (2024). *The object of art*. *Medium*. https://medium.com/signifier/the-object-of-art-43bae5a91bc0 [23 October 2024]

Delenda, O. (2013). The "cloth of Veronica" in the work of Zurbarán. *Bilbao Fine Arts Museum*, no. 7, pp. 125–161.

Fite-Wassilak, C, *Tate Etc.* (2018). *Objects that speak for themselves*. https://www.tate.org.uk/tate-etc/issue-42-spring-2018/chris-fite-wassilak-objects-speak-themselves [23 September 2024]

Gibbons, J. (2007). *Contemporary art and memory: Images of recollection and remembrance*. London: I.B. Tauris.

Hempton, G. and Grossmann, J. (2009). *One square inch of silence: One man's search for natural silence in a noisy world*. New York: Free Press.

Hughes, E. (1990). *Silver for collectors*. London: Treasure Press.

Koren, L. (2008). *Wabi-sabi for artists, designers, poets & philosophers*. Point Reyes: Imperfect Publishing.

Kosuth, J, New York: The Museum of Modern Art. (1999). *One and three chairs*. https://www.moma.org/collection/works/81435 [9 February 2025]

Levy, D. (2024). *The position of spoons: And other intimacies*. London: Hamish Hamilton.

Material Matters. (2018). *Material Matters with Grant Gibson – Episode: 8 May 2018* [Podcast]. https://open.spotify.com/episode/6dUENruDvqTst1dL1ygi63?si=ea57f5c0473549c6 [27 November 2023]

National Gallery of Scotland. (2020). *André Breton*. https://www.nationalgalleries.org/art-and-artists/28925 [23 October 2024]

Oberhelman, S.M. (2019). Inscribing votive offerings and Tamata: Narratives, artefacts, Asklepios, and Panagia. *Athens Journal of Humanities & Arts*, no.7 (volume 1), pp. 14–44.

poezieiseendaad. (2022). *Het was lente en ik liep door de stad... [Instagram post]*. https://www.instagram.com/p/DEpzmHnN3Zu/ [16 April 2025]

Redell, P.C. (2019). *Foucault, art, and radical theology: The mystery of things*. London: Routledge.

Risatti, H. (2009). *A theory of craft: Function and aesthetic expression*. Chapel Hill: University of North Carolina Press.

Science and Nonduality. (n.d.). *Silence is the presence of everything [Video]*. https://scienceandnonduality.com/videos/silence-is-the-presence-of-everything/ [16 April 2025]

Spinvis. (2002). *Spinvis* [Music]. Available at: https://open.spotify.com/track/5lQozZo5ESEJ1g2cWjetba?si=f4c7f25d13b84408 [15 March 2023]

Tanizaki, J., Harper, T.J. and Seidensticker, E. (2011). *In praise of shadows*. New York: Vintage Books.

Van der Kolk, B.A. (2014). *The body keeps the score: Brain, mind, and body in the healing of trauma*. New York: Viking.

Vanden Heede, S. and De Kinder, J. (2007). *Een bed bij het raam*. Tielt: Lannoo.

VPRO Metropolis. (2013). *Of Beauty and Consolation – Episode 2: Roger Scruton [Video]*. https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=xoybTk6TEX4 [7 October 2024]

Figure List

Fig.01: De Kinder, Jan. (2007). *Een bed bij het raam [Illustration].* Lannoo.

Fig.02: Gris, Juan. (1914). *The Table [Photo collage and gouache on canvas].* https://assets.moma.org/documents/moma_master-checklist_387301.pdf [13 February 2024].

Fig.03: De Verney, Jodie. (2023). *Flea Market [Photograph].* Artist.

Fig.04: Ray, Man. (1934). *André Breton's 'Slipper Spoon' [Photograph of found object].* https://www.tate.org.uk/tate-etc/issue-42-spring-2018/chris-fite-wassilak-objects-speak-themselves [3 December 2024].

Fig.05: Breton, André. (1935). *Poème Objet [Photograph of assemblage].* https://www.nationalgalleries.org/art-andartists/28925 [3 December 2024].

Fig.06: De Verney, Jodie. (2023). *Fragments Spoons 1 [Photograph].* Artist.

Fig.07: De Verney, Jodie. (2025). *Archive Dad [Photograph Collage].* Artist.

Fig.08: De Verney, Jodie. (2023). *Fragments Spoons 2 [Photograph].* Artist.

Fig.09: De Verney, Jodie. (2023). *Workbench [Photograph Collage].* Artist.

Fig.10: Hockney, David. (1937). *The Studio Meeting [Photograph].* https://www.christies.com/en/lot/lot-6471892 [28 February 2025].

Fig.11: Kosuth, Joseph. (1965). *One and Three Chairs [Photograph of installation].* https://www.moma.org/collection/works/81435 [16 May 2024].

Fig.12: Whiteread, Rachel. (1990). *Ghost [Photograph of sculpture].* https://chisenhale.org.uk/project/rachel-whiteread/ [7 December 2024].

Fig.13: De Verney, Jodie. (2023). *Scan Box [Photograph].* Artist.

Fig.14: De Verney, Jodie. (1997). *Scan Hands [Photograph].* Artist.

Fig.15: De Verney, Jodie. (2024). *Print on Fabric [Photograph].* Artist.

Fig.16: de Zurbarán, Francisco. (1658). *The Holy Face [Photograph of painting].* https://artsandculture.google.com/asset/the-holy-face/-wGuay5aVXZeZw?hl=en [3 December 2024].

Fig.17: Unknown. (2020). *Tamata for Sale along the Leoforos Megalochares, Tinos [Photograph of votive].* https://www.athensjournals.gr/humanities/2020-7-1-1-Oberhelman.pdf [16 May 2024].

Fig.18: De Verney, Jodie. (2023). *Installation View [Photograph].* Artist.

Fig.19: De Verney, Jodie. (2025). *Installation View Spring Exhibition [Photograph].* Artist.